

Jason, Gary. *Critical Thinking: Developing an Effective Worldview*. Belmont, CA: Wadsworth, 2001. 432 pages. \$57.95 paper. ISBN 0-534-57389-4.

Critical Thinking: Developing an Effective Worldview is a comprehensive introductory textbook for a lower division course in critical thinking. The text is written for courses that approach the topic of critical thinking from a philosophical perspective, rather than a perspective grounded in rhetorical principles. The text is organized around three major parts. The first part of the book introduces students to the basic elements of critical thinking; the second part explores the goals of critical thinking; and the final section overviews different application areas for critical thinking. In the first chapter of the text, Jason outlines “five basic criteria for rational thought” which include, clarity, relevance, consistency, justification, and explanatory/predictive power. He frames the entirety of the text around these basic criteria. The text is also constructed as a series of self-contained or “modular” chapters. Jason clarifies that the text is much too comprehensive to be covered in a single semester. His intent is for instructors to tailor reading assignments from the text to their specific course goals.

Part I of the text is the weakest portion of the book. Chapters One through Three intend to introduce students to the basic vocabulary used in a discussion of critical thinking. These definitions, however, are often quite obvious and become redundant. The examples used in these chapters are simplistic, adding to the already tedious nature of the prose. Chapter Four is the highlight of Part I. In this chapter, Jason provides a concise, yet instructive overview of how to identify the different parts of an argument. His explanation of an enthymeme is one of the most understandable I have seen in an introductory text. Although Chapter Five moves away from the tedious definitions presented in the earlier chapters, it errs on the side of being too abstract. In this chapter, Jason provides a brief overview of inductive and deductive logic, which he clarifies, is *not* the same as inductive and deductive reasoning. As most hybrid introductory texts in Communication Studies tend to approach induction and deduction as forms of reasoning, this distinction in Jason’s text could be quite confusing for students coming from a rhetorical rather than philosophical background. If an instructor selected to use Chapter Five, it should be positioned alongside later chapters that go into much more detail concerning inductive and deductive logic.

Part II of the text is the most developed and strongest portion of the book. In these chapters Jason goes into more depth when explaining key concepts, and moves into the use

of real word examples. Chapters Six and Seven work well as companion chapters. Chapter Six explores the problems language can create for critical thinking, and Chapter Seven presents ways in which to overcome these difficulties. Once again, however, the focus of this work as a philosophy text hinders an instructor's ability to link the material to a more rhetorical approach. Jason's skepticism of the function of figurative language in the development of argumentation might confuse students of rhetoric who have learned the role creativity plays in the construction of persuasive messages. Chapter Eight provides an excellent review of common fallacies. Chapters Nine and Ten offer dense, yet accessible, explanations of truth tables and Venn diagrams. The overview of truth tables may seem a bit complicated to a student unfamiliar with basic logic, but Jason provides ample examples and exercises to clarify the approach. Chapters Eleven and Twelve move into a more complete discussion of inductive logic. After the heavy focus on deduction in the previous chapters, this change of direction functions as a nice contrast. Chapter Eleven discusses observation, memory and testimony with a strong focus on how to assess the strength of testimony. Inductive generalization is the topic of Chapter Twelve. This chapter clarifies when to use generalizations and how to assess them, as well as an introduction into syllogisms. Chapters Thirteen and Fourteen are also strong companion chapters. These two chapters discuss arguments by analogy and causal inference. Part II ends with the weakest chapter of the group. The final chapter of this section is a brief discussion of how to form and assess hypotheses, but is too general to be of much use.

Part III of the text is a combination of three chapters discussing ways in which one may apply critical thinking skills. Chapter Sixteen takes students through a basic decision making cycle. The chapter is dull and basically common sense information. Chapters Seventeen and Eighteen are stronger. The strongest section of the entire text is found in Chapter Seventeen's discussion of how to apply critical thinking skills to advertising and consumer choice. Jason provides a clear and concise overview of Cialdini's research on decision-making heuristics, as well as a frank discussion of common manipulations by advertisers. In Chapter Eighteen, Jason describes how critical thinking skills may be used to evaluate political messages. This chapter is not nearly as strong as his analysis of advertising, but does offer some solid examples from political speeches and debates.

In terms of general style and arrangement, the text has both strengths and weaknesses. Initially, each chapter of the book includes a copious number of exercises for students to complete as a way to verify their understanding of the content. The inclusion of

these exercises is a strong aspect of the book, and having relevant exercises placed after each major concept, rather than lumped together at the end a chapter is a distinct advantage. Jason also provides the answers for all even numbered exercises at the back of the text. This allows students to check their work as they go, but also provides instructors with options for in class or take-home assignments. The major weakness of the text is its use of examples to clarify concepts within each chapter. This is especially true in the earlier chapters. Not only are many of the hypothetical examples overly simplistic, several demonstrate a lack of sensitivity for issues of diversity. In the examples, men tend to be rich and playful, whereas women are poor and liars. Several examples assume students will be amused by sexual innuendo when it is far more likely they will become annoyed with such trivial support material. Many of the chapters use the Clinton-Lewinsky scandal as a case study through which to examine concepts. As the book was published after Clinton left office, it seems more appropriate to cover more recent events. Other real world examples, however, are much stronger. When Jason moves away from hypothetical support and into examples based on excerpts from books, articles and speeches, his use of examples as explanatory tools becomes much stronger.

The use of weak supporting examples and the narrow focus of the text on critical thinking from a logician's perspective harm the efficacy of this text. Students will most likely become annoyed with the simplistic, dated, and somewhat redundant examples used in the text, and could easily distract them from fully engaging themselves in the material. Additionally, the text essentially removes the role of the rhetorician from the critical thinking process. Jason presents an approach to critical thinking and argumentation that seems to eliminate the use of innovation and style in the construction of persuasive messages. Although the text does instruct students how to be aware of abuses of innovation and style, it does not account for the many ways creativity with language and ideas can enhance the critical thinking process.

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